Puzzle Piece Symbol

In short

Many autistic people find the puzzle piece symbol old-fashioned or hurtful. It suggests they're a problem to solve, or missing a piece. Most prefer the infinity symbol.

Overview

You've likely seen the puzzle piece used to represent autism. While common, it is highly controversial. Many in the autistic community view it as outdated or offensive. Understanding why helps you be a better ally.

Here is a breakdown of the controversy:

- It implies autistic people are a 'puzzle' to be solved or have a piece 'missing'. This frames autism as a problem rather than a different way of being
- It was historically used by organisations focused on 'curing' autism. It represents an era where autistic people were talked about, not to
- The primary colours reinforce the myth that autism is just for children. This erases the existence and needs of autistic adults
- The community generally prefers the infinity symbol (rainbow for neurodiversity or golden for autism). See the Infinity Symbol highlight

Being mindful of imagery shows that you're listening to the lived experiences of the community.

Useful links

- The Ableist History of the Puzzle Piece Symbol for Autism
- The History of the Puzzle Piece